

What inspectors ask staff

The questions care staff get asked on the day, and what a good answer contains.

Under the inspection framework, inspectors speak to staff alone, permanent and agency, so people can say what they think. They also sit in on handover and watch how staff and children talk to each other. There is no script and there should not be one: a home that runs well does not need rehearsed answers. This page exists so nobody is surprised by the question.

The framework's own words on what it looks for: staff are "clear about, and follow, procedures for responding to concerns about the safety of a child"; children who go missing get a "well-coordinated" response; restraint is "used only when necessary" and every incident is "recorded, reviewed and monitored by leaders"; staff use "effective de-escalation techniques"; supervision is "regular and effective" and "focused on children's experiences".

"How would you report a concern about a child's safety?"

The steps in order, with names: your manager, the designated officer (LADO) and their number, who covers out of hours, and that you would write it down the same day. If the concern is about the manager, who then. Hesitation on the names is the usual gap.

"What do you do if a child goes missing?"

That child's own missing plan, not a generic one: when the police are called, who else is told (social worker, parents if the plan says so), what you do while they are gone, and the return home interview afterwards. Where the plan lives.

"When can you use physical restraint, and what happens after?"

Only to prevent injury or serious harm, only the holds you are trained in, never as a punishment. Afterwards: the record the same day, the child's view and yours, the manager's review, the debrief. If you are not yet trained, say so and say what you do instead.

"Tell me about the plan for a child you know well."

Their needs and risks, what the plan asks staff to do, what is working and what is not, and what the child says about it. Inspectors then open the file and look for the same story.

"What would you do if you saw a colleague do something wrong?"

The whistleblowing route, and that you can go outside the home: the Responsible Individual, the LADO, Ofsted. That you would not need permission, and would not be treated worse for it.

"How do you know what has happened to each child before your shift?"

Handover, the daily logs, the plan updates. Inspectors watch a handover, so this answer gets checked against what they see.

"What training have you had, and what is next?"

Your mandatory courses and whether they are in date, where you are with the level 3, and something you asked for. "I don't know when my first aid runs out" is the answer to avoid, and the training matrix is how you avoid it.

"How often are you supervised, and is it any use?"

The cycle (every four to six weeks is common), the last date, and an honest view. Supervision that is "a date and two signatures" is a finding; saying so is not.

"How do you calm things down before they escalate?"

What works for the children you know: the early signs, the distractions, the space, the words. A real example beats the policy.

What inspectors also watch

Handover between shifts. How adults speak to children, and whether children come to them. Whether the daily logs say what staff say. Whether agency staff know the same answers as permanent staff. Whether the manager's answers and the team's answers match.

The best preparation is a Tuesday habit, not a briefing: a team meeting where each of these is asked out loud, once a quarter, and the gaps get fixed.